
Sri Lanka Labour Force Survey Annual Bulletin 2025

Department of Census and Statistics
Ministry of Finance, Planning and Economic Development

Sri Lanka Labour Force Survey (LFS) is designed to measure the levels and trends of labour indicators in Sri Lanka. The survey was initiated in the first quarter of 1990 and is continued quarterly based on international standards recommended by the International Labour Organization (ILO)

The Survey used 25,000 sampled housing units across the country, based on districts and residential sectors. Accordingly, this Survey did not cover the collective residents and institutionalized population.

This bulletin contains labour force, employment and unemployment statistics based on the data collected from January to December 2025.

The 2025 annual estimates were reweighted based on Census of Population and Housing 2024 data

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- ☐ Labour force participation rate is 49.4% for the year 2025
 - ☐ Unemployment rate for the Survey period is 3.9%
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Source Publication

 <http://www.statistics.gov.lk/LabourForce/StaticInformation/Bulletins/SriLankaLabourForceSurveyAnnualBulletin-2025>

Labour Force

Working Age Population

All persons above specific age limit (15 years and above) of either gender are identified as working age population. This population consists with two groups namely economically active & inactive.

Economically Active Population (Labour Force)

The economically active population or the labour force comprises all persons of working age who are either "employed" or "unemployed" during the reference period (The week before the survey period)

Labour Force = Employed + Unemployed

Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR)

Labour force as a percentage of the population aged 15 years and over.

Table 1.1: Labour force participation rate by gender – 2025

Gender	Economically active population (No.)	Labour force participation rate
Total	8,408,251	49.4
Male	5,449,708	69.1
Female	2,958,543	32.4

Table 1.2: Distribution of economically active/ inactive population by gender – 2025

Gender	Economically active population		Economically inactive population	
	No.	%	No.	%
Total	8,408,251	100.0	8,625,859	100.0
Male	5,449,708	64.8	2,440,129	28.3
Female	2,958,543	35.2	6,185,730	71.7

Reported labour force participation rate is 49.4 in 2025 (Table 1.1). Given the estimated counts in Table 1.2 estimated economically active population is around 8.4 million. About 5.4 million (64.8%) of economically active population are males. Economically inactive population accounts for about 8.6 million and of that majority are females (71.7%).

Table 1.3: Percentage distribution of economically active population by gender and district – 2025

District	Economically active population (%)		
	Total	Male	Female
Total	100.0	64.8	35.2
Colombo	100.0	64.0	36.0
Gampaha	100.0	65.3	34.7
Kalutara	100.0	65.2	34.8
Kandy	100.0	62.9	37.1
Matale	100.0	65.7	34.3
Nuwara Eliya	100.0	58.5	41.5
Galle	100.0	62.9	37.1
Matara	100.0	65.2	34.8
Hambantota	100.0	68.3	31.7
Jaffna	100.0	71.2	28.8
Mannar	100.0	69.4	30.6
Vavuniya	100.0	61.6	38.4
Mullaitivu	100.0	71.7	28.3
Kilinochchi	100.0	77.4	22.6
Batticaloa	100.0	68.3	31.7
Ampara	100.0	74.6	25.4
Trincomalee	100.0	75.3	24.7
Kurunegala	100.0	62.3	37.7
Puttalam	100.0	68.2	31.8
Anuradhapura	100.0	64.6	35.4
Polonnaruwa	100.0	74.4	25.6
Badulla	100.0	58.8	41.2
Monaragala	100.0	64.7	35.3
Rathnapura	100.0	63.6	36.4
Kegalle	100.0	60.3	39.7

As shown in Table 1.3 percentage of female economically active population is lower than that of males in every district. The highest percentage of female economically active population is reported from Nuwara Eliya (41.5%) while the lowest reported from Kilinochchi (22.6%).

Employment

Employed

Persons, who worked at least one hour during the reference period, as paid employees, employers, own account workers or contributing family workers are said to be employed. This also includes persons with a job but not at work during the reference period.

Reference Period:

Previous week of the survey week
(3rd week of every month)

Employment Rate

The proportion of employed population to the total labour force.

Table 2.1: Employment statistics by gender – 2025

Employment Statistic	Sri Lanka	Male	Female
Employed population	8,079,040	5,299,777	2,779,262
Labour Force	8,408,251	5,449,708	2,958,543
Employment rate	96.1	97.2	93.9

Table 2.3: Percentage distribution of employed population by employment status and gender – 2025

Employment status	Total	Gender	
		Male	Female
Total	100.0	65.6	34.4
Employee	100.0	63.8	36.2
Employer	100.0	88.1	11.9
Own account worker	100.0	73.0	27.0
Contributing family worker	100.0	22.3	77.7

Figure 2.1 Percentage distribution of employment status - 2024

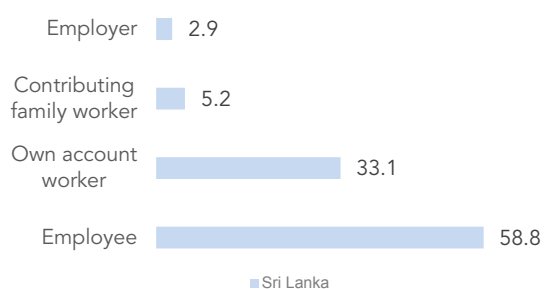


Table 2.2: Percentage distribution of employed population by major industry group Sector, province and District - 2025

Sector/province	Total	Major industry group		
		Agri.	Ind.	Ser.
Sri Lanka	100.0	23.9	26.2	49.8
Sector				
Urban	100.0	4.2	23.4	72.5
Rural	100.0	26.3	27.2	46.5
Estate	100.0	56.8	18.5	24.7
Province				
Western	100.0	5.0	31.7	63.3
Central	100.0	29.3	21.9	48.8
Southern	100.0	30.0	24.2	45.8
Northern	100.0	30.8	23.1	46.2
Eastern	100.0	27.0	23.8	49.2
North Western	100.0	24.6	30.3	45.1
North Central	100.0	41.0	18.9	40.2
Uva	100.0	44.4	16.3	39.2
Sabaragamuwa	100.0	32.5	28.1	39.3
District				
Colombo	100.0	2.5	25.7	71.8
Gampaha	100.0	3.4	35.8	60.8
Kalutara	100.0	12.1	35.3	52.6
Kandy	100.0	17.2	25.5	57.4
Matale	100.0	27.2	22.0	50.8
Nuwara Eliya	100.0	53.8	15.0	31.2
Galle	100.0	23.1	27.5	49.4
Matara	100.0	34.2	20.4	45.4
Hambantota	100.0	36.5	23.2	40.4
Batticaloa	100.0	19.3	27.0	53.7
Ampara	100.0	44.5	15.2	40.3
Trincomalee	100.0	37.3	21.6	41.1
Jaffna	100.0	55.6	15.6	28.8
Mannar	100.0	33.9	23.4	42.8
Vavuniya	100.0	25.4	25.9	48.8
Mullaitivu	100.0	30.4	23.0	46.6
Kilinochchi	100.0	24.2	22.2	53.6
Kurunegala	100.0	25.1	29.7	45.2
Puttalam	100.0	23.6	31.7	44.8
Anuradhapura	100.0	41.3	17.7	41.0
Polonnaruwa	100.0	40.2	21.7	38.1
Badulla	100.0	42.5	15.8	41.7
Monaragala	100.0	47.9	17.3	34.7
Rathnapura	100.0	39.3	26.9	33.8
Kegalle	100.0	23.0	29.9	47.1

Unemployment

Unemployed

Persons available and/or looking for work, and who did not work and taken steps to find a job during last four weeks and ready to accept a job given a work opportunity within next two weeks are defined as be unemployed.

Unemployment Rate

The proportion of unemployed population to the total labour force.

Table 3.1: Unemployment rates by age groups and gender – 2025

Age group (Years)	Sri Lanka		Gender	
	No.	(%)	Male	Female
Total	329,211	3.9	2.8	6.1
15 – 24	153,610	19.5	16.5	24.5
25 – 29	82,274	10.6	6.7	17.1
30 – 39	51,923	3.0	1.5	5.6
Over 40	41,404	0.8	0.5	1.3

Among all age groups, unemployment rates of females are higher than those of males. Youth unemployment (age 15 – 24 years) rates are the highest for both sexes, compared to other age groups (Table 3.1).

Table 3.2: Unemployment rates by level of education and gender – 2025

Level of Education	Sri Lanka		Gender	
	No.	(%)	Male	Female
Total	329,211	3.9	2.8	6.1
Below G.C.E. (O/L)	99,564	2.2	1.8	3.3
G.C.E. (O/L)	89,157	5.5	4.2	8.2
G.C.E. (A/L) & Above	140,491	6.0	3.9	8.3

According to the Table 3.2, when level of education is considered the highest unemployment rate (6.0%) is reported from the G.C.E. (A/L) & above group. It is 3.9 percent and 8.3 percent for male and female respectively.

Table 3.3 and Table 3.4 show the distribution of unemployment rates by sector, province & district respectively. When the provincial distribution considered the highest unemployment rate is reported from Southern province (5.3%). Female unemployment rates are higher compared to that of male in all provinces. In Southern province comparatively very high female unemployment rate is observed. When the district level distribution is considered the highest unemployment is reported from Hambantota District (6.6%) while the lowest rate is reported from Mannar.

Table 3.3: Unemployment rates by gender and province – 2025

Sector/ province	Unemployment rate (%)		
	Total	Male	Female
Sri Lanka	3.9	2.8	6.1
Sector			
Urban	3.4	2.5	5.0
Rural	4.0	2.7	6.3
Estate	4.8	4.2	5.8*
Province			
Western	3.1	2.4	4.4
Central	4.8	3.4	7.2
Southern	5.3	3.7	8.2
Northern	3.1	1.9	6.1
Eastern	2.9	1.3*	7.4
North Western	4.0	2.8	6.2
North Central	3.6	2.3*	6.1
Uva	4.5	3.6	5.9
Sabaragamuwa	4.2	3.1	6.1

* These figures are to be treated with caution, as the corresponding CV (Coefficient of variation) values are high.

Table 3.4 Unemployment rates by district – 2024

District	Unemployment rate (%)	District	Unemployment rate (%)
Colombo	3.0	Kilinochchi	4.8*
Gampaha	2.6	Batticaloa	4.3
Kalutara	4.3	Ampara	3.3*
Kandy	5.9	Trincomalee	0.6*
Matale	4.9	Kurunegala	4.3
Nuwara Eliya	2.6*	Puttalam	3.3
Galle	4.9	Anuradhapura	3.8
Matara	4.8	Polonnaruwa	3.1*
Hambantota	6.6	Badulla	4.1
Jaffna	3.4*	Monaragala	5.2
Mannar	1.8*	Rathnapura	2.9
Vavuniya	3.0*	Kegalle	6.0
Mullaitivu	1.7*		

* These figures are to be treated with caution, as the corresponding CV (Coefficient of variation) values are high.

Selected Labour Force Indicators

Indicator	Year							
	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Labour force participation rate								
by gender								
Total	51.8	52.3	50.6	49.9	49.8	48.6	47.4	49.4
Male	73.0	73.0	71.9	71.0	70.5	68.6	67.4	69.1
Female	33.6	34.5	32.0	31.8	32.1	31.3	29.8	32.4
by residential sector								
Total	51.8	52.3	50.6	49.9	49.8	48.6	47.4	49.4
Urban	49.6	50.2	47.0	46.9	47.2	46.0	44.3	46.5
Rural	52.3	52.7	51.3	50.5	50.3	49.1	48.0	49.9
Unemployment Rate								
by gender								
Total	4.4	4.8	5.5	5.1	4.7	4.7	4.4	3.9
Male	3.0	3.3	4.0	3.7	3.7	3.6	3.0	2.8
Female	7.1	7.4	8.5	7.9	6.5	7.0	7.1	6.1
by selected age group (year)								
20-29	15.0	15.3	18.1	18.3	16.2	17.0	16.1	13.9
20-24	20.1	20.3	25.2	26.8	21.8	21.6	20.7	17.8
25-29	10.4	11.0	12.0	11.4	11.7	13.0	12.5	10.6
by selected educational level								
GCE A/L and above								
Total	9.1	8.5	9.8	9.1	7.8	8.0	7.8	6.0
Male	5.1	5.0	6.2	6.2	5.5	5.8	5.4	3.9
Female	13.2	11.9	13.6	12.2	10.1	10.2	10.3	8.3
Employed population								
by gender								
Total	8,015,166	8,180,693	7,999,093	8,113,507	8,147,731	8,009,916	7,949,751	8,079,040
Male	5,300,310	5,368,896	5,372,947	5,414,280	5,373,965	5,307,563	5,358,554	5,299,777
Female	2,714,855	2,811,796	2,626,146	2,699,228	2,773,766	2,702,354	2,591,197	2,779,262
by industry (percentage)								
Total	8,015,166	8,180,693	7,999,093	8,113,507	8,147,731	8,009,916	7,949,751	8,079,040
%	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0
Agriculture	2,043,698	2,071,940	2,169,679	2,213,015	2,158,559	2,088,344	2,066,651	1,932,548
%	25.5	25.3	27.1	27.3	26.5	26.1	26.0	23.9
Industry	2,239,262	2,258,421	2,152,746	2,109,482	2,158,199	2,043,154	2,031,417	2,120,455
%	27.9	27.6	26.9	26.0	26.5	25.5	25.6	26.2
Service	3,732,206	3,850,332	3,676,668	3,791,011	3,830,973	3,878,418	3,851,683	4,026,037
%	46.6	47.1	46.0	46.7	47.0	48.4	48.5	49.8
by no. of hours per week (percentage)								
Total	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0
* 0	5.6	6.4	14.6	9.6	5.8	4.2	2.5	2.6
1-9	1.7	1.7	2.1	2.0	2.1	2.4	1.8	2.0
10-39	25.7	26.8	27.1	29.6	31.9	31.2	28.3	28.7
40 & above	66.9	65.1	56.2	58.7	60.3	62.1	67.4	66.7

*Has a job but not at work during the reference week

Note: Age 15 years and over population is considered as working population

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